A SHORT TALK · ABOUT 4 MINUTES

Ramen's fat problem

What is really in the bowl, and how to keep eating it smarter.

noodles · broth · tare · oil · toppings

WHY THIS MATTERS

Ramen is eaten billions of times every year

~120 bn

instant noodle servings eaten worldwide in a year

2–3 min

to make a pack, which is why it is a weeknight default

1 bowl

can carry most of a day's fat, depending on the style

Instant-noodle volume: World Instant Noodles Association annual demand estimates (roughly 120 billion servings in 2023).

EXHIBIT A · ONE PACK OF INSTANT RAMEN

A single pack, before any toppings

~14 g
total fat

~6.5 g
saturated fat, about a third of the 20 g daily value

~380 kcal
for a block most people eat in one sitting

Share of the 78 g daily fat value — 18%



Typical values for an 85 g fried-noodle pack; brands vary. Daily values: FDA, 78 g fat and 20 g saturated fat on a 2,000 kcal diet.

Instant noodles are fried in palm oil

- Fresh noodles are steamed, then **flash fried** to drive out water. That is what makes the block shelf-stable.
- The frying oil soaks in: fried blocks are often **around 20% fat by weight**.
- The usual oil is **palm oil**, which is roughly half saturated fat.

~50%

of palm oil's fat is saturated, versus roughly 15% for canola oil.

Non-fried (air-dried) instant noodles exist and usually carry far less fat; check the label.

EXHIBIT B · A RESTAURANT TONKOTSU BOWL

The shop bowl can be most of a day's fat

40–60 g
fat, a common estimate for a full tonkotsu bowl

800+ kcal
often well over, with extra noodles (kaedama)

12+ hrs
of hard boiling that emulsifies bone fat into the broth

Share of the 78 g daily fat value (at 55 g) 71%



Restaurants rarely publish nutrition; figures are estimates and vary widely by shop, portion, and toppings.

ANATOMY OF A BOWL

Where the fat hides

The broth

Pork bones boiled hard turn milky because fat and collagen emulsify into the soup.

Chashu

Braised pork belly, often two or three slices, is one of the fattiest cuts.

Aroma oil

A spoon of lard, chicken fat, black garlic oil (mayu) or chili oil floats on top.

Back fat

Seabura, pork back fat shaken over some styles, adds richness by the spoonful.

Butter

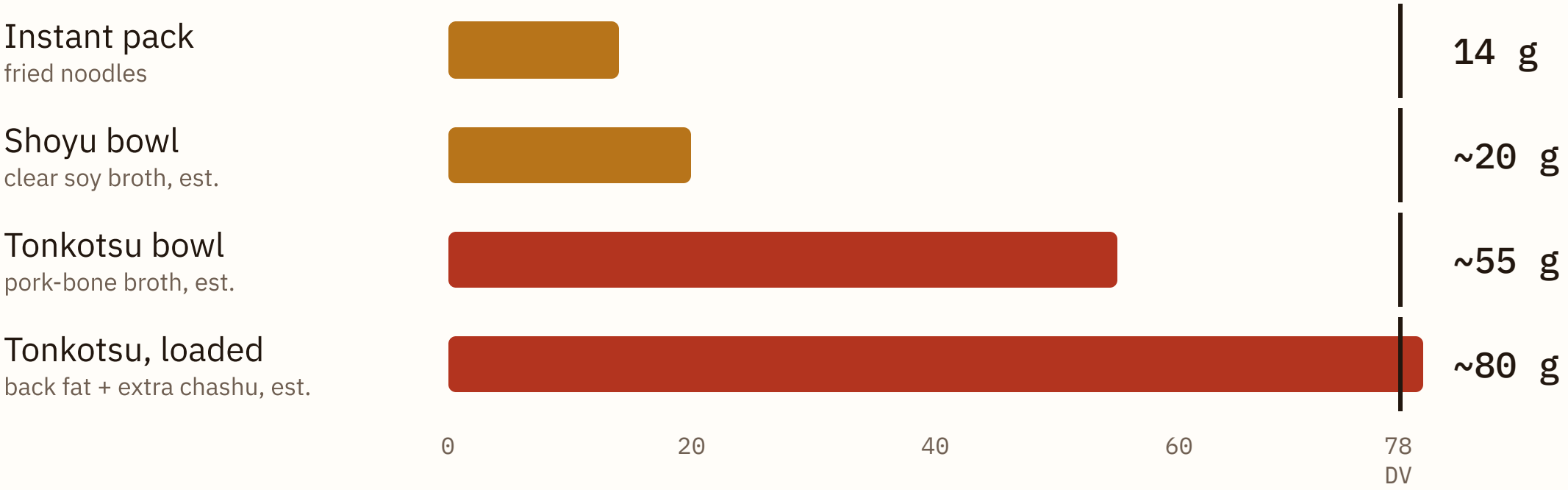
A pat on Sapporo-style miso butter corn ramen melts straight in.

Fried extras

Karaage, fried garlic and tempura bits pile on more oil.

FAT PER SERVING, GRAMS

On one scale against the daily value



Scale 0–80 g. Restaurant values are illustrative estimates, not lab measurements.

THE HEALTH ANGLE

Saturated fat raises LDL cholesterol

- Saturated fat raises **LDL cholesterol**, a major risk factor for heart disease.
- The American Heart Association suggests under **6% of calories** from saturated fat, about **13 g a day** on 2,000 kcal.
- A 2014 study of Korean adults linked eating instant noodles **2+ times a week** to higher odds of metabolic syndrome in women.

13 g

AHA saturated-fat target for a whole day. A rich tonkotsu bowl can reach it alone.

AHA dietary guidance on saturated fat; Shin et al., Journal of Nutrition, 2014. Associations, not proof of cause.

AND IT BRINGS SALT ALONG

Most of the fat and salt sits in the soup

1,500–2,000 mg
sodium in a typical bowl or pack with its full seasoning

2,300 mg
FDA daily value for sodium

Soup
is where the seasoning, oil and rendered fat end up

Share of the 2,300 mg sodium daily value (at 1,750 mg) 76%



Typical label ranges for instant packs; restaurant bowls are often similar or higher.

FIXES

Leave the soup and order shoyu or shio

At the shop

- Order **shoyu or shio**, clear broths, instead of tonkotsu.
- **Leave most of the soup**. Eat the noodles and toppings.
- Say no to **back fat** and the extra oil spoon.
- Swap chashu for **chicken, egg or tofu**; add bean sprouts and greens.

At home

- Buy **non-fried** (air-dried) noodles.
- Use **half the seasoning packet** and skip the oil sachet.
- Cook the noodles, **drain the water**, then add fresh hot water or stock.
- Bulk it up with **spinach, cabbage, an egg**.

THE ASK

Keep the bowl.
Try one swap this week.

Leave half the soup, pick a clear broth, or use half the packet.

Thank you.